departments of the GoI, the state and UT governments to take effective measures to prevent the spread of COVID-19 in the country.

During a briefing at the prime minister's residence where the Minister of State for Chemicals and Fertilizers Mansukh Mandaviya (now Union health minister), senior bureaucrats from the Department of Chemicals and Fertilizers and our scientific experts were present, it was discussed that India would need to not only scale up the manufacturing of all artificial respiratory apparatus, oxygen therapy apparatus and any other breathing appliances or devices, but we would also have to ban exporting these for the time being. It was also decided on the same day that India would ban the export of sanitizers as well.

Over the past few days, the use of anti-malarial drug hydroxychloroquine (HCQ) as a potential prophylactic drug was being heavily discussed in the international media. President Donald Trump's endorsement of it in mid-March especially fuelled the scientific community to seriously look at the capability of this drug in fighting the novel coronavirus.[7] Fox News also interviewed Gregory Rigano, the co-author of a new study showing the benefits of two drugs widely used to treat malaria. The Fox News anchor asked Rigano, 'How big a game-changer would chloroquine and its sister drug hydrochloroquine be if say, we began using it fairly promptly to treat Americans who are highly at risk?' The author replied, 'The drugs were effective in treating COVID-19 and could be used as a prophylactic to prevent contracting the disease.' He pointed out to another study of 30 patients, half of whom had received HCQ and the other half a placebo and said, 'Within a matter of six days, the patients taking HCQ tested negative for coronavirus… the patients that took the control tested positive.' Several other studies from around the world published in reputed journals and outlets highlighted the effectiveness of the early use of HCQ in inhibiting SARS-CoV-2 infection.[8]

Assessing the potential of this drug and the huge demand it would create worldwide, the attendees of the meeting at the prime minister's residence recommended that India ban supply of the drug in order to first meet needs of its own population. However, the prime minister looked uncomfortable with that suggestion. He wasn't one for this kind of hyper-nationalism during a humanitarian crisis. He said, 'In the interest of humanity, it would be wrong to ban a potentially lifesaving drug. This is a moment when India can save lives and we can't let it go. We should look at